

Don't Be Fooled! Information Detective Skills

GRADES 3-5

30 MINUTES

LIBRARY

Students connect optical illusions to information literacy, learning that just as our eyes can be tricked, we can be fooled by unreliable information—and developing the detective skills to tell the difference.

LEARNING OBJECTIVE

Students will understand that just as optical illusions trick our eyes, misleading information can trick our brains; learn the STOP-CHECK-ASK framework for evaluating information; and practice applying these skills to real examples.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

AASL I.B.3: Learners generate new knowledge by generating products that illustrate learning.

AASL I.D.1: Learners demonstrate mastery by selecting information in a variety of formats.

TEKS §110.5 (3) 13B: Identify credibility of sources.

MATERIALS NEEDED

- Spirit photography examples from Mini Museum
- Sample "fake news" headlines (age-appropriate)
- STOP-CHECK-ASK poster or visual
- **Mini Museum Perception Lab:** minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving/illusions

RECOMMENDED BOOKS

Fake News: Separating Truth from Fiction

by Danielle Smith-Llera

True or False? A CIA Analyst's Guide

by Cindy L. Otis

LESSON PLAN

Hook: Tricking Your Eyes (5 minutes)

Display 2-3 classic optical illusions. Let students vote on which line is longer, then reveal they're the same.

"Your eyes just got TRICKED. These are optical illusions—pictures that fool your brain. Now here's my question: If your eyes can be tricked by a simple picture... can your BRAIN be tricked by information?"

Historical Connection: Spirit Photography (5 minutes)

Show spirit photography examples from the exhibition.

"Over 150 years ago, William Mumler claimed he could photograph ghosts. He charged grieving families lots of money to see images of their dead loved ones. Thousands believed it was real. Was it? No—he used 'double exposure' to fake it. This teaches us: just because something LOOKS real doesn't mean it IS real."

Direct Instruction: STOP-CHECK-ASK (8 minutes)

1 STOP — Before you believe it or share it, PAUSE! Don't let excitement push you to act fast.

2 CHECK — Who wrote this? When? Is it from a reliable place? Can you find the same info elsewhere?

3 ASK — Ask a trusted adult (librarian, teacher, parent) if you're not sure.

Lesson Plan (continued)

Activity: Real or Fake? (8 minutes)

Present 3-4 examples and have students apply STOP-CHECK-ASK:

- "Scientists discover chocolate is healthier than vegetables!" — Fake (too good to be true)
- News article from known newspaper about local event — Reliable (known source, verifiable)
- Social media post with "facts" but no source — Suspicious (needs checking)
- Spirit photograph from 1870 — Fake (historical hoax)

For each: "What step helps you here? STOP, CHECK, or ASK?"

Mini Museum Exploration (3 minutes)

"When you visit the Mini Museum, look at the artifacts with your Information Detective skills. The Victorian illusion cards show how artists played with your eyes. The spirit photographs show how people can be fooled when they don't check sources. The lesson is the same across 150 years: LOOK CAREFULLY before you believe!"

Closing (2 minutes)

"Today you became Information Detectives. You learned that just like optical illusions trick your eyes, misleading information can trick your brain. But now you have a tool: STOP-CHECK-ASK. Use it whenever something seems surprising, exciting, or scary!"

Mini Museum Connection

Option 1 — Visit: Spirit photography provides a powerful historical example of visual misinformation. Students see the challenge of distinguishing real from fake isn't new.

Option 2 — Virtual: Explore at minimuseumproject.com/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

ASSESSMENT

Application: Can students correctly apply STOP-CHECK-ASK to sample scenarios?

Understanding: Can students explain why spirit photography fooled people?

Exit ticket: "Name one question you should ask before believing something online."

DIFFERENTIATED STUDENT HANDOUTS

- **Green:** STOP-CHECK-ASK visual guide with simple scenarios
- **Yellow:** Evaluate multiple sources, explain reasoning
- **Red:** Research historical hoax, create misinformation awareness guide